공손하게 거절하기: “좀 어려울 것 같아요”

This worksheet shows how Koreans say no politely.

WHAT THIS IS FOR

You can find the reason and the alternative in a polite Korean refusal and tell whether a soft reply means yes or no.

1 FOUR PARTS OF A POLITE NO

1	2	3	4
감사·사과 (thank or apologize first)	이유 (give a short reason)	부드러운 거절 (say no softly)	다른 제안 (offer another time or option)

2 USEFUL REFUSAL EXPRESSIONS

1. **말씀은 감사하지만** (thank you for asking, but)
   Thank the person first so the no feels softer.
   예: 말씀은 감사하지만 오늘은 먼저 들어가 볼게요.
2. **죄송한데** (I'm sorry, but)
   Use it before a refusal to show you feel bad about saying no.
   예: 죄송한데 그날은 다른 일정이 있어서요.
3. **-아서요/-어서요** (it's because ...)
   Giving only the reason often works as the refusal itself.
   예: 요즘 일이 좀 많아서요.
4. **-기가 좀 어려울 것 같아요** (it seems a bit hard to)
   It means no, but sounds much softer than 못 해요.
   예: 이번 주 안에 끝내기가 좀 어려울 것 같아요.
5. **괜찮습니다** (no, thank you)
   It politely turns down food, drinks, or help someone offers you.
   예: 저는 괜찮습니다. 많이 드세요.
6. **마음만 받을게요** (the thought is enough)
   Use it to politely turn down a gift or a favor.
   예: 선물까지는 괜찮아요. 마음만 받을게요.
7. **생각해 볼게요** (I'll think about it)
   It often means a soft no rather than a real maybe.
   예: 지금 바로 결정하기는 어려워서요. 생각해 볼게요.
8. **다음에 꼭** (definitely next time)
   It offers another chance so the other person does not feel rejected.
   예: 오늘은 어렵고, 다음에 꼭 같이 가요.

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3 CULTURE TIP: READING BETWEEN THE LINES

1. **In many countries, a clear "No, thanks" is polite**
2. **In Korean, 싫어요 or 안 돼요 alone can sound cold**
3. **That's why Koreans often give a reason and leave the no unsaid, as in 금요일 밤은 약속이 있어서요**
4. **When you read a reply, look for the reason (-아서요) and the alternative (다음에), then decide if it means yes or no**

All dialogues are short, everyday examples of refusing invitations, offers, and requests at work and with friends.

4 YOUR TURN

READ AND DECODE REFUSALS

Read each Korean reply, then find the information, judge the meaning, or write a softer version.

1. Read and answer in English: What is 나 (B)'s reason, and what does 나 (B) suggest instead? — 가: 이번 토요일에 등산 같이 갈래요? 나:
   같이 가자고 해 줘서 고마워요. 그런데 토요일에는 동생 이사를 도와줘야 해서요. 다음 달에 같이 가요.

2. Does the speaker accept (Yes) or refuse (No)?:
   ①마음만 감사히 받을게요.
   ②좋아요, 몇 시에 만날까요?
   ③이번에는 좀 힘들 것 같아요.
   ④그럼 저도 한 잔만 할게요.

3. Fill in the blank with a polite way to decline the offer: 가: 커피 한 잔 더 드릴까요? 나:
   아니요, 저는 ____. 충분히 마셨어요.

4. Put the sentences in the order of a polite refusal (thanks → reason → refusal → alternative):
   (가) 다음 주에는 시간이 될 것 같아요. (나) 초대해 주셔서 감사해요. (다) 이번 주는 출장이 있어서요. (라) 이번에는 못 갈 것 같아요.

5. Rewrite this direct refusal more softly, using -기가 좀 어려울 것 같아요:
   금요일까지 보고서를 못 보내요.

✓ ANSWERS

1) Reason: B has to help a younger sibling move house on Saturday. Suggestion: go hiking together next month.
2) ① No ② Yes ③ No ④ Yes
3) 괜찮습니다 (괜찮아요 / 그만 마실게요)
4) 나 → 다 → 라 → 가
5) 금요일까지 보고서를 보내기가 좀 어려울 것 같아요. (보내기 좀 어려울 것 같아요 / 보내기가 좀 어려울 것 같습니다)

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